

Forward-facing
horns

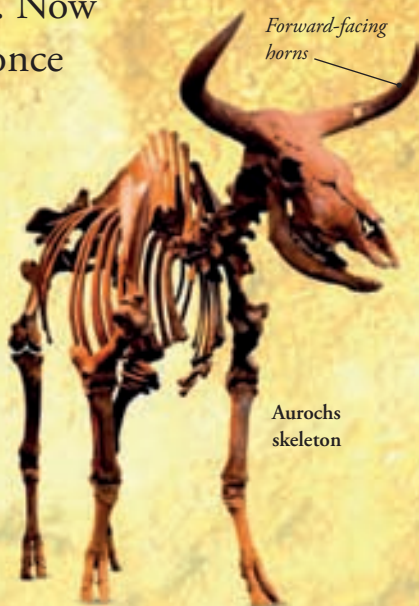


What the heck?

In the 1920s, two German brothers, Heinz and Lutz Heck, tried to breed the aurochs back into existence. The brothers found breeds of domestic cow with aurochs-like qualities, such as the large-horned highland cattle of Scotland and the fierce fighting bulls of Spain. By crossing the breeds, they produced a new variety—heck cattle—that looks like a small aurochs.

Aurochs

The docile cattle seen on farms today are descendants of a much wilder, fiercer, and bigger ancestor: the aurochs. Now extinct in the wild, the aurochs once roamed in herds across Europe and Asia. Stone Age people hunted these fearsome animals and made paintings of them in caves, such as the one shown on this page. Wild aurochs survived in Europe until 1627, when the last animal was killed in Poland.



Forward-facing
horns

Aurochs
skeleton

Aurochs

OR-ocks

- **When** 2 million–500 years ago
- **Fossil location** Europe, Africa, Asia
- **Habitat** Forests
- **Length** 9 ft (2.7 m)
- **Diet** Grass, fruit, and plants

Much larger than a domestic cow, the aurochs weighed about a ton and had a very powerful, muscular neck and shoulders, and huge, curved, forward-facing horns. Long feet and high ankles made it a fast runner, and it could also swim short distances. Males may have had a black coat and females a reddish-brown one. Both had a pale stripe along the spine.

